



officially emerged as a people in 1238. Other Thai-speaking people live in China, Laos, and Burma. Thailand has a royal family, whose history dates back 700 years. The monarchy of Thailand prides itself on constantly

adapting to ensure that it fits in with the modern world, its people, and society. Thai culture retains a distinctiveness that the people are very proud of. Almost all share the Buddhist faith, which has helped to bind them.

Rural life

The towns of Thailand are surrounded by small farming villages, many of which have developed different traditions and styles of dress. The villages are made up of family groups or clans ruled by a headman and his council.

FARMING VILLAGES

The villagers cooperate with each other becoming like a large, extended family. Every village has a temple, or *wat*, used as a meeting place as well as for worship.



THAI BOXING

Muay Thai, or Thai boxing, is one of Thailand's most popular sports. The roots of this martial art can be traced back to medieval times, and it is not just a sport but an extravagant event. Before every match, the two fighters dance to special boxing music to honor and pay respect to the trainer, family, and to the sport.



AKHA HEADRESS

The Akha people who live in the hilly regions of northern Thailand are known for their elaborate headdresses. These are adorned with silver balls and colored beads and are worn regularly by the women, not just on ceremonial occasions.



YAO PEOPLE

The Yao people are best known for their clothing. The women wear a black turban, a long tunic with a large red ruff sewn into the front, and heavily embroidered pants. The embroidery itself is a craft tradition of which the Yao are particularly proud.